THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Prelim

Twelve rooms: how to practise, reading the notes, how long a note lasts, time signatures, repeats, touch, major and minor scales, your first chords, ear training and a review. Then the exam corner.

THE ROOMS

1 · Practising well
2 · The staff and the keyboard
3 · Reading the notes
4 · How long is a note?
5 · Time signatures
6 · Repeats and road signs
7 · Touch: smooth, short, strong
8 · Major scales
9 · Minor scales
10 · Chords and triads
11 · Ear training
12 · Review
The exam corner

PRELIM · ROOM 1

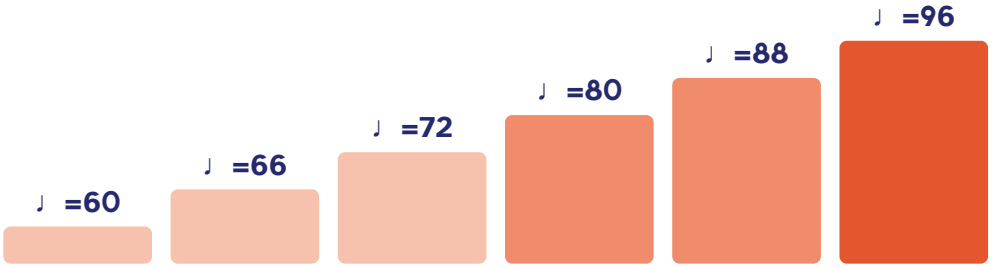
Practising well

More in the Handbook, pp. 165–166

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Slow, small, and correct; then a little faster; then join the pieces.
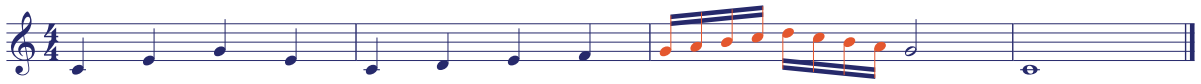


three correct times at one speed, then one step up

Slow and correct, one step at a time

EXAMPLE

Which bar first?



?

1. **Play it through once.** Where did it slip?
2. **The semiquavers** in bar 3: hardest?
3. **Start there**, slowly.

Bar 3, the semiquavers: practise the **hardest bar first**, slowly, then join bars 2–4.

PRELIM · ROOM 1 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 The metronome ladder ★☆☆

The Handbook's ladder (p. 165) climbs one notch at a time: 60, 66, then the next. Write the next three steps. The first is done.

60 66 **72** ☐ ☐

2 Good habit? ★☆☆

Circle helps or wastes time. The first is done.

the hardest bar first	**helps** · **wastes time**
always from the top	**helps** · **wastes time**
faster to fix a slip	**helps** · **wastes time**
three correct, then faster	**helps** · **wastes time**
hands separately first	**helps** · **wastes time**

3 My fifteen minutes ★★☆

Plan your practice: what will you do in each part?

TIME	WHAT
2 min · warm up	
5 min · hardest bars	
5 min · join them	
3 min · play it through	

PRELIM · ROOM 2

The staff and the keyboard

More in the Handbook, pp. 29–31

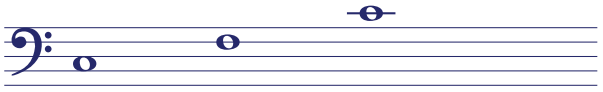
SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Every line and every space is one white key, in order.

EXAMPLE

From the page to the key



C F Middle C

1. **Name the note:** line 4 of the bass staff, between the clef's dots, is F.
2. **On the piano,** find the three black keys just below Middle C.
3. **F is the first key** of that family: play it with the left hand.

The bass-clef F is the **F just below Middle C**: left of the three black keys under it.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play Middle C, then walk up.

Say each white key as you play it, C D E F G A B C, and picture each one climbing the staff: line, space, line, space.

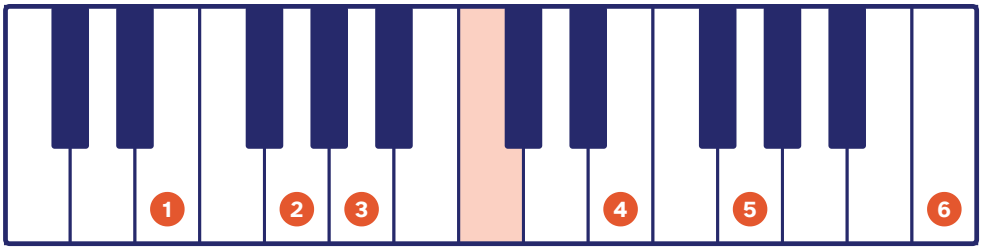
PRELIM · ROOM 2 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Which key?

★☆☆

Middle C is marked. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



1 E 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

2 Count from Middle C

★☆☆

Count the notes, both ends included. The first is done.

FROM	TO	NOTES
Middle C	up to treble G	5
Middle C	down to bass F	☐
Middle C	up to A	☐
Middle C	down to E	☐
G	up to the next G	☐

3 Mirror notes

★☆☆

Complete each sentence.

Treble G and bass F are both note ☐ from Middle C.

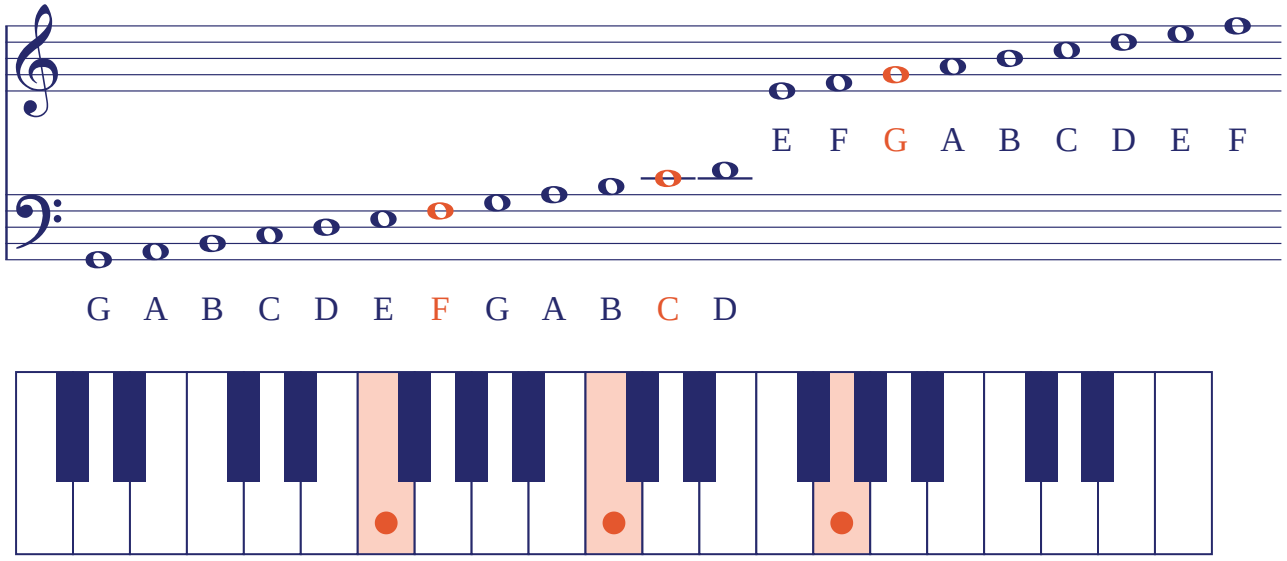
Treble G is on line ☐ of the treble staff; bass F is on line ☐ of the bass staff.

PRELIM · ROOM 3

Reading the notes

More in the Handbook, pp. 32–35

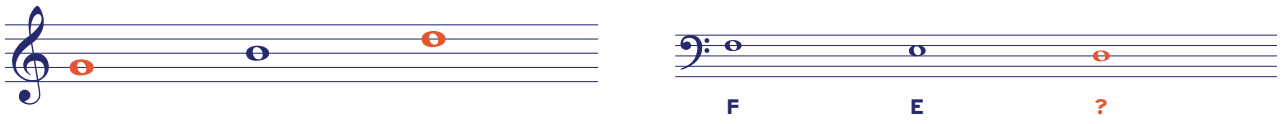
SCAN TO LISTEN



Middle C in the middle; treble G and bass F, the clef notes, either side. Every line and space is the next letter, with its own key underneath (the keyboard starts on G, so its first black keys belong to a group of three).

EXAMPLE

Read a line note with its sentence



1. **Treble lines:** *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*. The red note on line 4 is the fourth word.
2. **Bass lines:** *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*. The red note on line 3 is the third word.
3. **Check each** from its clef note: treble G, bass F.

Treble line 4: **D** (Deserves). Bass line 3: **D** (Dragons). Same letter, different keys: the clef decides.

PRELIM · ROOM 3 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 The letters on the staff

★☆☆

Write the letters from the bottom up. The first row is done.

Treble lines	E	G	B	D	F
Treble spaces					
Bass lines					
Bass spaces					

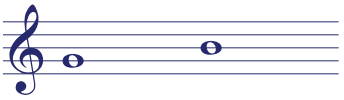
2 Step or skip?

★☆☆

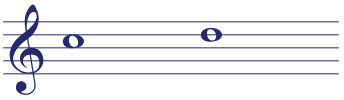
Circle step or skip. The first is done.



step · skip



step · skip



step · skip



step · skip



step · skip

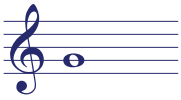


step · skip

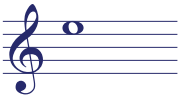
3 Treble clef notes
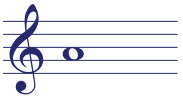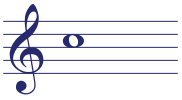
★☆☆

Write the letter name under each note. Start from G. The first is done.

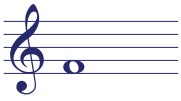


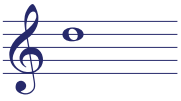
G

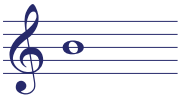


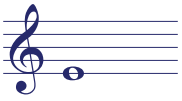












PRELIM · ROOM 4

How long is a note?

More in the Handbook, pp. 56–58

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

A dot adds half. A tie glues two notes into one.
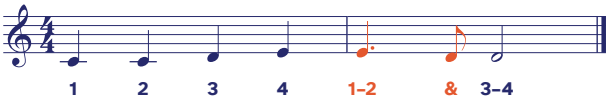


2 beats **2 + 1 = 3 beats**

The dot adds half

EXAMPLE

A dotted crotchet you already know: Ode to Joy



1. **Bars 3–4 of Beethoven's Ode to Joy.** Sing it: "C C D E, E — D D".
2. **The red E is a dotted crotchet:** 1 + ½ = 1½ beats, held through "1 & 2".
3. **The quaver D** falls on the "&" of beat 2; the last D takes beats 3 and 4.

Long–short, then long: the dot is why the tune **leans** before it lands.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Clap once, hold for three.

Say "1 2 3" as you hold: a dotted minim. Then a dotted crotchet and quaver: "1 (& 2) &".

PRELIM · ROOM 4 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Note sums

★☆☆

Add up the beats (crotchet = 1 beat). The first one is done.













2 Clap and count

★☆☆

Clap the dotted rhythms, counting the “&” inside each dotted crotchet. Tick a circle each time it is steady.



3 In your music

★☆☆

Find each of these in a piece you are learning.

FIND IN A PIECE YOU ARE LEARNING	PIECE	BAR
a dotted minim		
a dotted crotchet		
a tie		
a rest of one whole bar		

PRELIM · ROOM 5

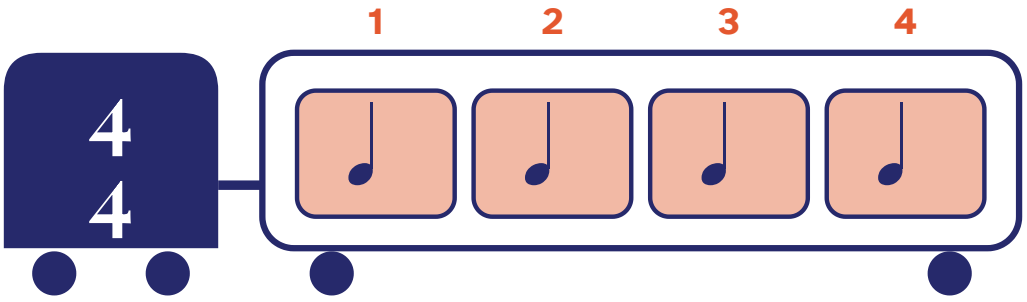
Time signatures

More in the Handbook, pp. 59–61

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

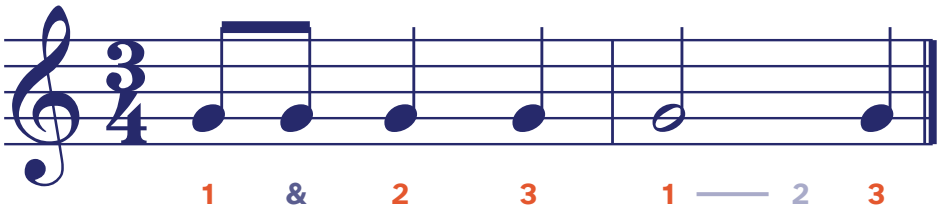
Top number: how many beats. Bottom number (in simple time): which note gets one beat.



Top: how many seats · bottom: which note sits in one

EXAMPLE

What does 3/4 mean?



1. **The top number:** how many counts in each bar?
2. **The bottom number:** 4 stands for a crotchet. Which note gets one count?
3. **Check a bar:** does it add up?

3/4: **three crotchet beats** in every bar (two quavers + crotchet + crotchet = 3).
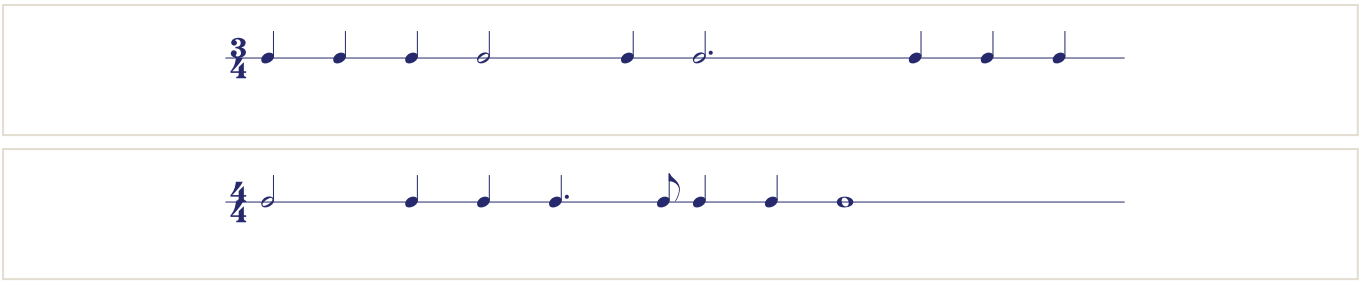
PRELIM · ROOM 5 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Add the bar lines

★★☆

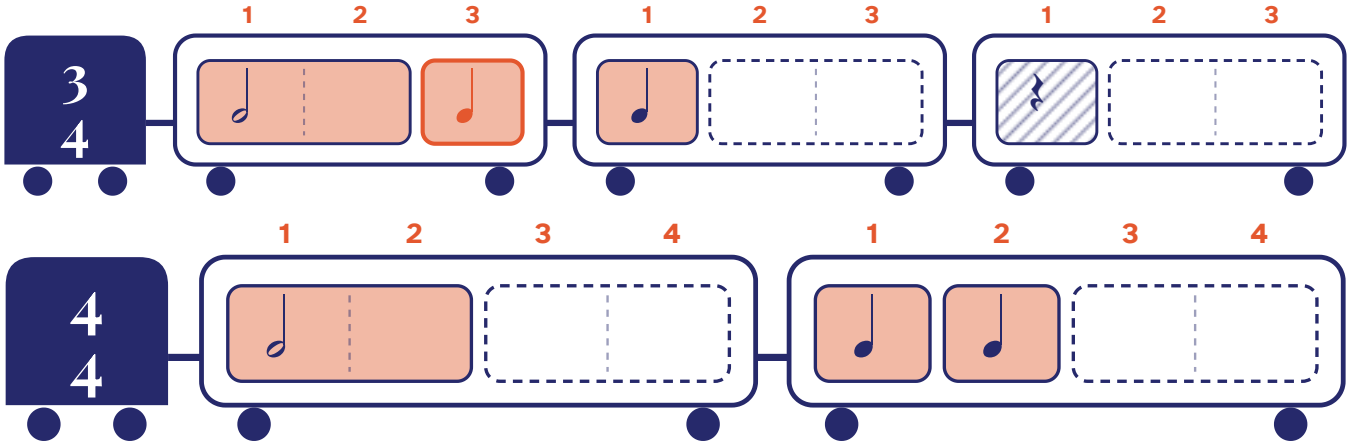
Draw a bar line after every full bar, and a final bar line at the end.



2 Book every seat

★★☆

Each carriage is one bar of the time signature on the engine. Draw one note or rest in the dashed seats so every seat is booked. The first is done.



PRELIM · ROOM 6

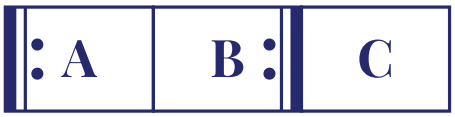
Repeats and road signs

More in the Handbook, pp. 71–73

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Two dots facing back mean: go back and play it again. A first-time bar is played once; the second time through, you skip it and play the second-time bar.

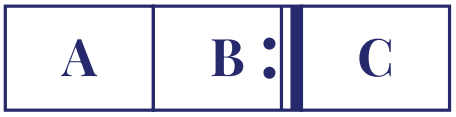


You play: A → B → A → B → C

Two dots facing back mean: go back and play it again

EXAMPLE

In what order do you play these bars?



You play: ? ? ? ? ?

1. **Play A and B.**
2. **B ends with a repeat sign** facing back. There is no start sign: where do you go back to?
3. **Play it again,** then carry on.

Back to the very start: **A B A B C**.

PRELIM · ROOM 6 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Write the order

★☆☆

Each letter is one bar. Write the letters in the order you play them. The first is done.

THE MUSIC	YOU PLAY
A B :|	**A B A B**
|: A B :| C	
A |: B C :|	
|: A :| |: B :|	

2 First and second time

★★☆

The bar marked 1 is played the first time only; the second time you skip it and play the bar marked 2. Write the order. The first is done.

THE MUSIC	YOU PLAY
|: A [1. B :| [2. C	**A B A C**
|: A B [1. C :| [2. D	
|: A [1. B :| [2. C D	

3 True or false?

★☆☆

Circle T or F.

With no start sign, a repeat goes back to the very beginning.	T F
A repeat sign means: play the bars between the signs three times.	T F
The second time through, you skip the first-time bar.	T F
Two dots beside a double bar line make a repeat sign.	T F

PRELIM · ROOM 7

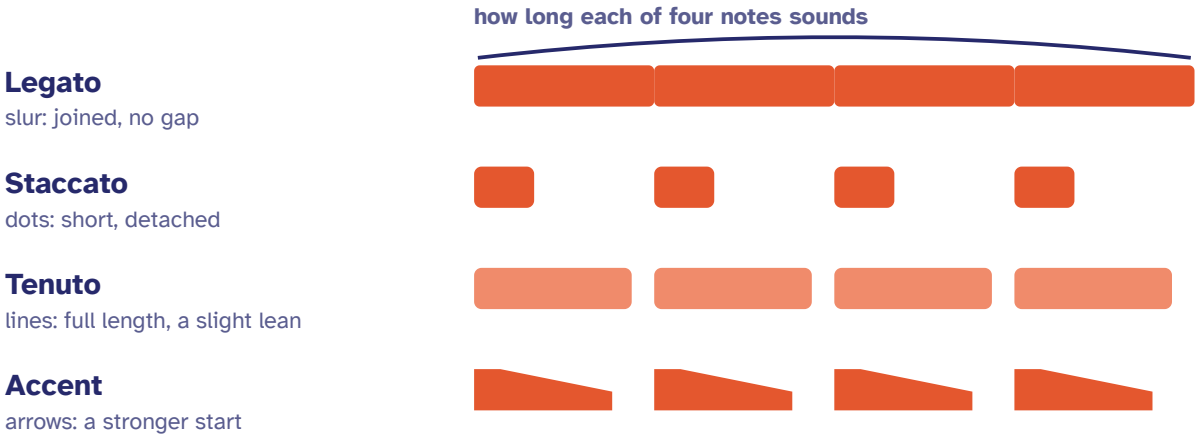
Touch: smooth, short, strong

More in the Handbook, pp. 79–81

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET
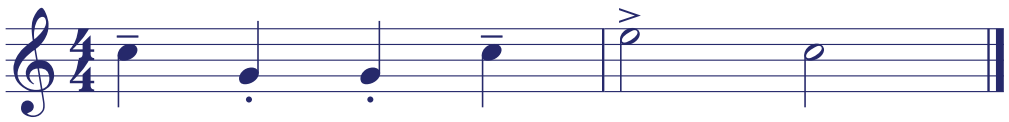
Curve: join. Dot: short. Line: hold. Arrow: strong.



Same notes, four touches

EXAMPLE

Line, dot or arrow?



?

1. **The first two Cs have lines:** how long?
2. **The Gs have dots.**
3. **The E in bar 2** has an arrow.

The first two Cs held their **full length**, the Gs short, the E strong, and the last C plain, held for its two beats.

PRELIM · ROOM 7 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Which notes are short?

★★☆

Look at the music and complete the sentences. The first is done.



Bar 1 is played [joined] (joined or short).

In bar 2, [ ] notes have dots.

The last G has an [ ] .

2 Slur or tie?

★☆☆

Circle slur or tie. The first is done.

a curve over C D E	**(slur)** · **tie**
a curve joining G and G	**slur** · **tie**
a curve over E F	**slur** · **tie**
a curve joining two Bs	**slur** · **tie**

3 Play it

★☆☆

Hot Cross Buns: play E D C joined, then short and bouncy. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

PRELIM · ROOM 8

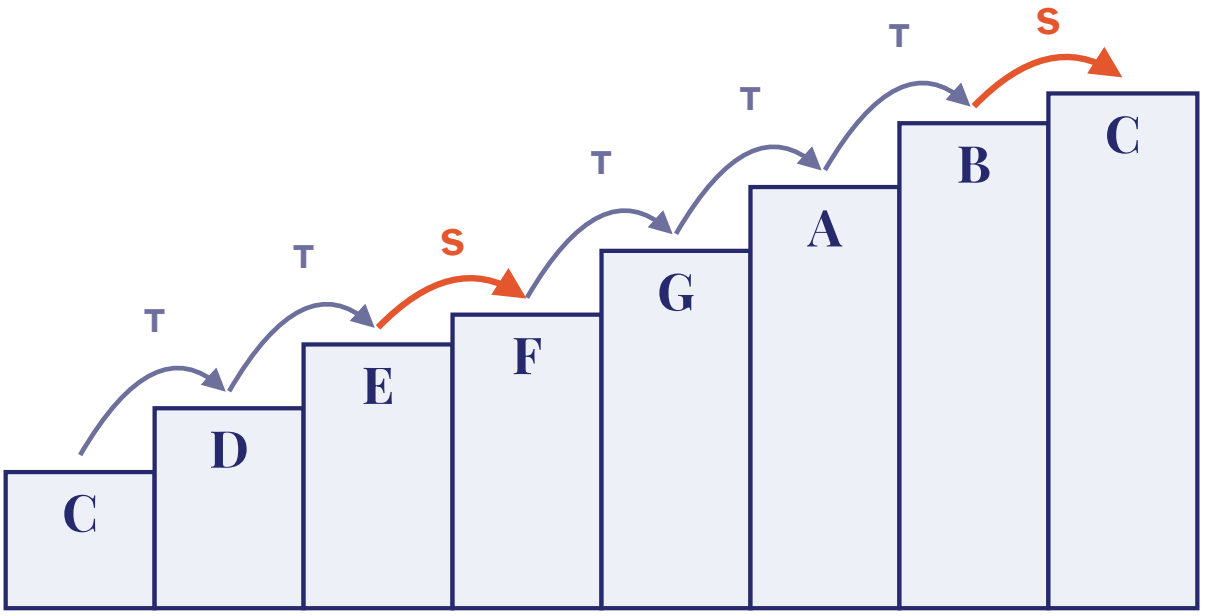
Major scales

More in the Handbook, pp. 93–95

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

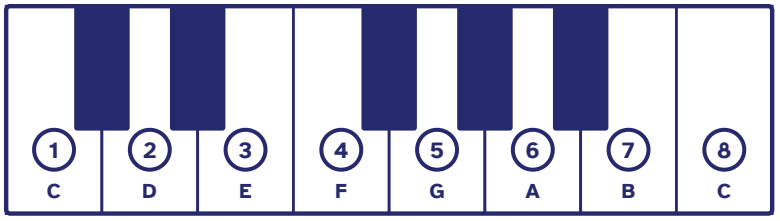
Every major scale: tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone.



Tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone

EXAMPLE

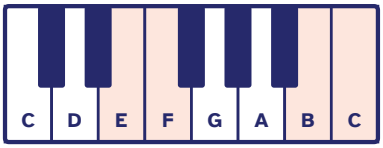
Where are the short steps?



1. **Play C up to C** on the white keys, numbering the notes 1 to 8.
2. **Between each pair,** look for a black key. A key between means a tone.
3. **Which pairs have no black key** between them?

Only **3–4** (E–F) and **7–8** (B–C): nothing between. Those are the two short steps of every major scale.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



One finger, C to C.

Play the white keys from C up to C and say “tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone”. Feel the two short steps.

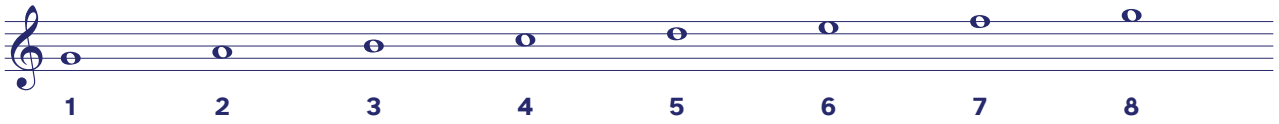
PRELIM · ROOM 8 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Fix the scale

★★☆

This should be G major, but one note is missing its sharp. Add it, then answer.



the note that needs a sharp ☐ semitones between degrees ☐ – ☐ and ☐ – ☐

2 The major pattern

★☆☆

Write T or S between each pair of degrees.

1 [T] 2 [T] 3 [ ] 4 [ ] 5 [ ] 6 [ ] 7 [ ] 8

PRELIM · ROOM 9

Minor scales

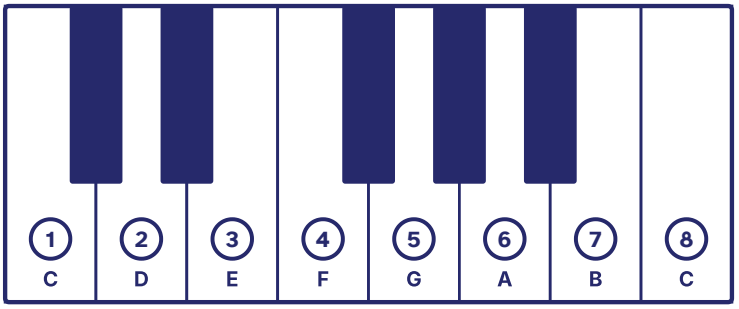
More in the Handbook, pp. 96–98

SCAN TO LISTEN

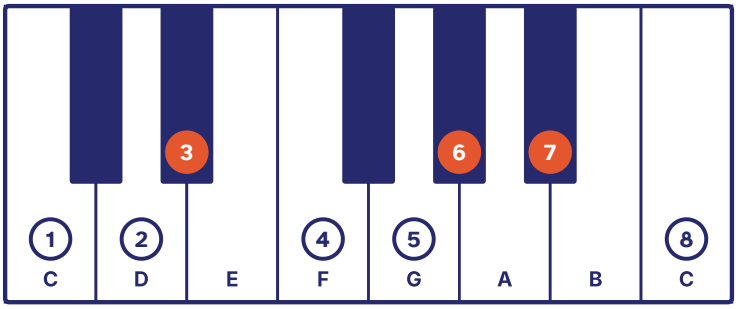
THE SECRET

Minor = the major on the same note with 3, 6 and 7 one key lower.

C major
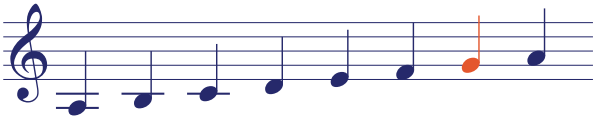


C minor: 3, 6 and 7 move one key left



The same home note · three notes one key lower

EXAMPLE

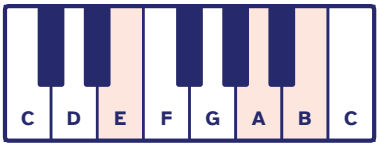
Build A harmonic minor



1. **Start from A natural minor:** A B C D E F G A, all white.
2. **Take note 7** (the ?) and raise it one key.
3. **Name it.**

Note 7 becomes **G♯**: A harmonic minor is A B C D E F G♯ A.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Major, then minor.

Play C major, then play it again with E, A and B one key lower. Same home, new colour: bright, then dark.

PRELIM · ROOM 9 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Which notes move?

★☆☆

From C major to C natural minor, three degrees move one key lower. Write their numbers.

☐ ☐ ☐

2 Build it

★★☆

Write the notes of each scale, going up. The first is done.

SCALE	NOTES
C natural minor	**C D E♭ F G A♭ B♭ C**
D natural minor	
A harmonic minor	
D harmonic minor	
E natural minor	

PRELIM · ROOM 10

Chords and triads

More in the Handbook, pp. 110–112

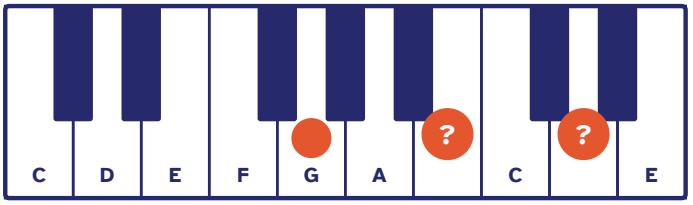
SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Play one, skip one, play one: the cake rule.

EXAMPLE

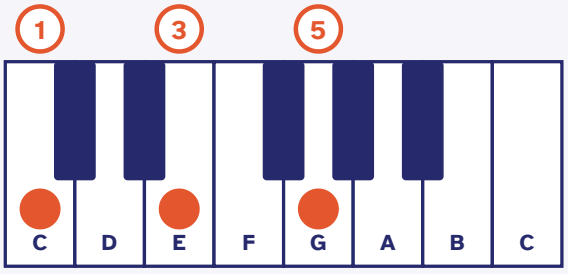
Build a triad on G



1. **Start on G** (the red dot): the root, the bottom layer.
2. **Skip one white key,** take the next: the first ?.
3. **Skip again,** take the next: the second ?.

G **B D**: the triad of **G**. Same shape as C E G, just moved up.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C. Fingers 1, 3, 5 down together.

That is the C chord. Slide your hand to any white key and do it again: the cake shape always works.

PRELIM · ROOM 10 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Build it

★☆☆

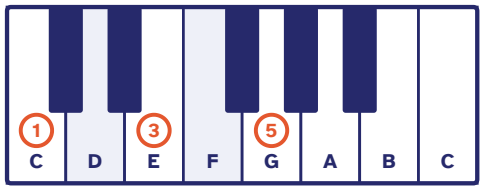
Write the 3rd and the 5th above each root: play one, skip one. The first row is done.

ROOT	3RD	5TH	ROOT	3RD	5TH
C	E	G	G		
D			A		
F			B		

2 On the keyboard

★☆☆

Mark the root, 3rd and 5th of the F triad with 1, 3 and 5. The C triad is done.



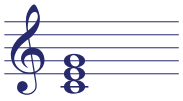


C triad C E G **F triad**
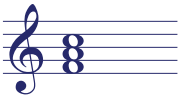
3 Name the triad
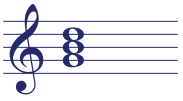
★☆☆

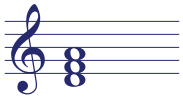
Write the root of each triad: the bottom note names it. The first is done.
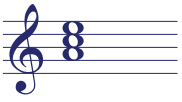


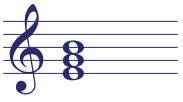
C











PRELIM · ROOM 11

Ear training

The listening tests of this level

SCAN TO PLAY

THE SECRET

Sing it out loud. If you can sing it, you can hear it; if you can hear it, you can play it.

	TEST	IN THE EXAM
1	**Clap the beat**	The examiner plays in two- or three-beat time, slow, moderate or quick. You clap the beat, and keep going after the music stops.
2	**Echo the rhythm**	The examiner plays a simple two-bar rhythm. You clap, tap, hum or sing it back.
3	**Sing the tune**	The examiner plays five or six notes, then again slowly. You sing or hum each note.
4	**Higher or lower?**	The examiner plays two notes, one after the other, at least a 3rd apart. You say which is higher or lower.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Sing before you play.

Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

Based on the aural tests of the AMEB 2026 syllabus. Check the current syllabus with your teacher before an exam.

PRELIM · ROOM 11 · PRACTISE

Practise

Away from the screen, with a grown-up or your teacher. Tick a circle each time.

1 Clap the beat ★☆☆

Your teacher or a grown-up plays the part of the examiner. The examiner plays in two- or three-beat time, slow, moderate or quick. You clap the beat, and keep going after the music stops.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

2 Echo the rhythm ★☆☆

Your teacher or a grown-up plays the part of the examiner. The examiner plays a simple two-bar rhythm. You clap, tap, hum or sing it back.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

3 Sing the tune ★☆☆

Your teacher or a grown-up plays the part of the examiner. The examiner plays five or six notes, then again slowly. You sing or hum each note.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

4 Higher or lower? ★☆☆

Your teacher or a grown-up plays the part of the examiner. The examiner plays two notes, one after the other, at least a 3rd apart. You say which is higher or lower.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

PRELIM · ROOM 12

Review: a step further

Short parts of chapters from the level before, one step further

SCAN TO OPEN

THE SECRET

Go back to go forward: each part adds one step to a room you have already finished.

	THE STEP FURTHER	CHAPTER	HANDBOOK
1	**The two ends and the eight Cs**	The keyboard	pp. 22–26
2	**Tempo, strong and weak beats**	Pulse, tempo and the bar	pp. 50–52
3	**Quavers, stems and flags**	Notes and rests	pp. 53–55
4	**mp, mf and the hairpins**	Loud and soft	pp. 76–78

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



One part a day.

Listen to the part in the app, then play its drill. Five minutes is enough.

PRELIM · ROOM 12 · PRACTISE

Practise

For each part: listen, play its drill, then tick. Three ticks and it is yours.

1 The two ends and the eight Cs

★☆☆

The keyboard, Handbook pp. 22–26.

○ ○ ○

2 Tempo, strong and weak beats

★☆☆

Pulse, tempo and the bar, Handbook pp. 50–52.

○ ○ ○

3 Quavers, stems and flags

★☆☆

Notes and rests, Handbook pp. 53–55.

○ ○ ○

4 mp, mf and the hairpins

★☆☆

Loud and soft, Handbook pp. 76–78.

○ ○ ○

PRELIM · THE EXAM CORNER

If you take an exam

This level is about the standard of a Preliminary exam.

THE SECRET

An exam asks: can you play your pieces and your scales, hear what is played, and say what is on your page?

Pieces

Chosen with your teacher. Everything in this book is there to help you read and shape them.

Technical work

- Scales, hands separately, one octave: **C major** and **G major**; **A minor** and **E minor**, natural and harmonic.
- Two short technical exercises, chosen with your teacher.

Aural tests

The listening tests are Room 11 of this book: one game for each test.

General knowledge

The examiner points at your music and asks about:

- the names of the **notes** and **rests** in your pieces, and how long each lasts
- every **sign** and **word** printed in your pieces: what it means
- the **key** of each piece, and its **time signature**

Sight-reading

There is no sight-reading test at this level. It starts at Grade 1.

Based on the AMEB 2026 syllabus. Syllabuses change: check the current one with your teacher before you enter.

PRELIM · THE EXAM CORNER

Four weeks to go

Tick a box when it is true. Go through the list again each week.

- [ ] I can play each piece from start to finish without stopping.
- [ ] I can say the key and the time signature of each piece.
- [ ] I can name every sign and word on my pages.
- [ ] I can play each scale slowly, evenly, with the right fingers.
- [ ] I have played all the ear games in Room 11 this week.
- [ ] I have played my pieces for someone at home.
- [ ] I know how to walk in, sit, set the stool and breathe out before I play.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play it for someone.

Each week, play one piece for a person at home, as if it were the exam: walk in, bow, play, bow.